

Chapter 2

Modern education systems and impact on ethnic minorities

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The development of modern education in Thailand aimed primarily at backing up the foundation of the nation-state in a spirit of Thai-ness and modernity. In that respect, local cultures and identities were cast aside by the government. However, with the rise of communism in the region after 1949 and the support of Communism in border areas, the Thai government found it necessary to re-conquer these regions, and proceeded to do so via public education, among other solutions. The curriculum taught in schools did not take into account the specificities of the children who were taught the same subject and in the same language (Central Thai) as their lowland counterparts. Attempts have been made to improve education and safeguard local indigenous culture, showing the importance of keeping the opportunity for people to find alternative ways of development in an ever more complex world.

Introduction

The development of modern education in the highlands of Northern Thailand over the last fifty years was meant to enable young highlanders to gain more knowledge about the modern world and new technologies. By doing so, it was hoped they would be better integrated within the broad scope of society, and have access to more employment opportunities and a higher socio-economic status.

But only a few highlanders have benefited from this modern education system. Many who had gained some levels of education did not have the chance to continue to higher education and compete with the majority for qualified jobs. Furthermore, modern ideology and knowledge inculcated in schools have increasingly replaced traditional knowledge and practices. Without them,

educated highlanders have found it hard to go back to their hill villages to live like their parents used to.

Modern education for highlanders has therefore been felt as an issue that needs to be remedied. After describing the development of modern education in Thailand, this chapter provides details about the discrepancies and limitation of modern education in developing highlanders' quality of life²⁷. It outlines attempts made by the state, especially through the local content provision, but also by Non-Governmental Organizations (NGOs) and Peoples' Organizations (POs) to develop alternative educational systems which would better serve the interests of the local and ethnic communities, and the nation.

1. Development of the modern education system in Thailand

The modern education system was established along with other modern institutions at a time when Thailand was changing into becoming a modern nation²⁸. Before the modern system was established, two types of educational systems existed.

The first one was the royal school established to give education to royal families: *"in the reign of King Narai Maharaj, education was prosperous.(...) According to the chronicle, Phra Trat Noi, King Pethrajah's son, had studied and was expert in many languages namely Pali, Sanskrit, French, Khmer, Laos, Vietnamese, Burmese, Mon and Chinese. He had also studied the horoscope and medicine from many teachers. The foundation of Thai language lessons was laid out since then. It is known that Phra Horathibodi wrote the Thai language teaching text, called Jinda-manee, and gave it to King Narai Maharaj"*²⁹.

The second system was the education for monks. A book written by a French priest, published in 1854, depicted this system as follows: *"After or before*

²⁷ On the prejudices towards highlanders, see the comprehensive database collated by the CESD and available on its website, www.cesd-thai.info

²⁸ The unification and centralization of the country took place during the reign of King Rama V around the end of the 19th century in the time of British and French colonization of Burma and Indochina. Before that, each region was autonomous and ruled by a specific royalty in each Kingdom, for example the Lanna Kingdom in the North.

²⁹ <http://www.moe.go.th> (open on December 7, 2006), website of the Ministry of Education, in Thai, quote translated by the author

*the kon juk*³⁰ ceremony, fathers and mothers will send their sons to stay at the temple to learn how to read and write. There, boys serve monks, row boats for them and eat food, which is offered to the monks, together with the monks. In exchange, the monks teach boys how to read books one or two times a day. For girls, there are cooking classes: pounding chilli paste, making sweets and also preparing betel nuts and leaves".³¹

During the Ayutthaya kingdom period³², especially during Phra Narai Maharaj reign (1656-1688), foreign missionaries set up churches and schools to teach people who wanted to convert to Christianity. They taught not only religion but also other modern subjects. The Ayutthaya Kings sent many of their kin and close aids to study in those schools (Wyatt 1969). Some kind of modern instruction was therefore introduced in Siam, but schools were few in numbers and were not accessible to ordinary people.

The need for extended modern education began during the time Siam was threatened by the British and French empires, which was under the reigns of King Rama IV and King Rama V. The British government successfully occupied the whole Burma in 1885, while the French colonial government had occupied most of the Indochina area before that. Siam lost the territory on the left of the Mekong River and important towns in the East³³ to the French in the very early years of the twentieth century.

To testify these changes, the colonisers wanted to initiate many treaties. Thus there was a need for people who knew foreign languages as the record below demonstrates: *"In 1822, the British East India Company wanted to expand its trading to Bangkok. Makwis Hesting, India representative appointed John Crawford to be a consul to establish the agreement for cooperation. The discussion between John Crawford and Thai autocrats took place in a very difficult way because they could not directly talk with each other. Crawford had to speak English with his translator, who then translated into Malay for Thai translator who had to translate into Thai for the autocrat... Because of this difficulty, in that time the agreement could not be reached".*³⁴

³⁰ Literally, "shave a topknot". Traditionally, the central Thai boys had to wear topknots. The ceremony to shave a topknot was held when a boy becomes adult.

³¹ <http://www.moe.go.th>, website of the Ministry of Education (open on December 7, 2006) in Thai, quote translated by the author

³² The Ayutthaya kingdom which is widely known as Siam existed for 417 years, from 1350 to 1767 A.D.

³³ The towns of Siemreap, Battabong and Srisophon

³⁴ <http://www.moe.go.th> (open on December 7, 2006), website of the Ministry of Education, in Thai, translated by the author

Next to these practical matters, and in the historical context of colonization, King Rama IV and others in the ruling class launched national reformation projects and set up a modern and centralized educational system in order to prepare people to have the same knowledge as Westerners. There was an urgent need to enter the modern era by developing the industry and trading sector, thus the demand for “educated” people who held new knowledge. Moreover, educated people were required to work in government organizations which were expanding to build the new nation.

The development of modern education started during the reign of King Rama IV by sending young royal family members to study abroad. In 1871, King Rama V opened the Rajkumara (Prince) School in the royal palace. In 1887, the Education Department was established to oversee education and religious affairs. In 1892, the Dharmakan Ministry was set up to oversee education, religion, nursing and museums. The Ministry also encouraged Christian missionaries and private sectors to create schools. Schools for girls were set up such as Sawapha Girl School, established by Queen Somdej Phra Sri Patcharintra Borom Rajini in 1897 and the School to Teach Girls Only (*rongrian bamrung wichasatri*) in 1901.

In 1898, the government proclaimed a law to organize education at the provincial level. The law emphasized that school should be spread nationwide, and use modern curriculum. The educational level was divided into pre-school, primary, secondary, occupational and higher education. Modern schools at the beginning were set up in the temples with monks serving as teachers; this allowed saving money by avoiding to build school buildings and to hire teachers. Only after 1909 were primary schools taken away from the *Sangha* ³⁵.

The turning point of state-managed education was the Compulsory Education Act, proclaimed in 1921 under the reign of King Rama VI. The Act demanded that every child, both boys and girls aged from 7 to 14, attend schools that were using the centrally-designed curriculum and Central Thai language as

³⁵ More information on the development of state managed education on <http://www.moe.go.th/main2/article/4-histo1.htm> and <http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Chulalongkorn>. See also details on the change from temples' managed education to state-managed education in Keyes, C. F. (1991). *The Proposed World of the School: Thai Villagers' Early into a Bureaucratic State System. Reshaping Local Worlds: Formal Education and Cultural Change in Rural Southeast-Asia*, C. F. Keyes. New Haven, Connecticut, Monograph 36/ Yale Southeast Asia Studies, Yale University Center for International and Area Studies; pp.89-130.

a teaching medium. The number of state schools increased from 275 in 1915 to 445 in 1922 ³⁶.

The change from an absolute monarchy to a parliamentary system in 1932 was another important landmark in the management of education by the state. Priority was given to education, and government plans stated that people had to get 4 years of primary school and another 8 years of secondary school education. The Thai government launched different programmes to broaden opportunities: non-formal education (for children who were not able to attend normal schools), special education (for disabled children), and welfare education (for children who could not access normal system schools due to socio-cultural problems) ³⁷.

The state gave much importance to education as the primary means to create national unity and to support modern economic sectors. With this in mind, schools were set up everywhere including remote and hill areas. The first school launched in the highland ethnic community was the Ban Lao Ta School in a Hmong village in Umphang District, Tak Province in 1935 ³⁸. In 1937, another school was set up in a Lua village in Bo Luang village, Hod District, Chiang Mai (Kosump 1984, p.18). In 1956, the Border Patrol Police (BPP) established a primary school for Akha students at Sa Ngo Village, Chiang Saen District, Chiang Rai Province. The BPP served as teachers but study materials were given by the Ministry of Education and student uniforms by the Public Welfare Department.

However, before 1956, although the state had set up some schools in ethnic communities, there were still very few of them due to a limited budget and no road access. But the state started to be interested in the highlanders due to the Cold War situation and the fear that hill tribes living in border areas might take side with the Thai Communist Party.

³⁶ Illiterate men aged from 20 to 45 years were even taxed to mobilize money to set up schools. This taxation scheme was however abolished in 1930 due to the world economic depression. See for more details, http://www.nfe.go.th/page_aboutus.php, site of Non Formal Education Commission (Commission of the Ministry of Education), page accessed on 10th May 2006.

³⁷ http://sunsite.au.ac.th/thailand/education/edu_thai/special.html, website of Assumption University, Bangkok.

³⁸ Tribal Research Institute, 1985, p.76, referred in Renard, R. D. and al. (1994). Twenty Years of Highland Health and Educational Development. Two Decades of Thai-UN Cooperation in Highland Development and Drug Control: Lessons Learned - Outstanding Issues - Future Directions. Paper presented at a seminar organized by the United Nations International Drug Control programme (UNDCP) in cooperation with the Office of the Narcotics Control Board (ONCB), 20-22 June 1994, Chiang Mai, Thailand

2. The “hill tribes” of Thailand in the geopolitics of the Cold War

The “hill tribes” in northern Thailand consist of ten groups: Karen, Hmong (Miao or Meo), Mien (Yao), Akha, Lahu, Lisu, Lua, H’tin, Khmu and Mlabri. It is estimated that, presently, there are about one million “hill tribe” people inhabiting the northern and north-western parts of Thailand³⁹. Though all groups have their specificities, they were subsumed under the broad category of “hill tribes” based on their mountainous habitat.

Traditionally, each highland ethnic group had its own knowledge and culture epitomized in its language, costume, and house style. Their distinctive ways of life could be explained by their development in isolation caused by the remoteness of their habitat. Self-sufficient production was found among all groups, with the exception of opium, sold for family income by a few of them. Primary sources for food were household animal husbandry, local crops, and forest produces and animals. Knowledge supported daily necessities, and referred to cultivation techniques, hunting wild animals, gathering forest produces, or herbal medicines, for instance. Their history and traditions were passed on orally to younger generations, as hill tribes did not rely on a written literacy.

Many groups were native of the area well before the creation of the modern Siamese nation-state, but though they had long inhabited territories that were integrated into Siam at the end of the nineteenth century, the Thai government had not paid real attention to them until after the Second World War.

The attitude towards highlanders changed when the Communist Party took over in China in 1949. The Communist movement influence in Southeast Asia started in the late 1950s, and communist propaganda among the hill tribes in mountainous area along the border of Thailand and Laos gained momentum in early 1960s. The Chinese Communist Party gave strong support to other Communist Parties in the Mekong region, and the Communist Party of Thailand (CPT) built strongholds in the highlands and increasingly gained followers and supporters from highland ethnic groups. In 1965, the CPT began armed fighting against the Thai government. Within this context, and advised by US experts, the Thai government focused on the highland ethnic peoples, portrayed as a potential threat to Thai national security.

³⁹ Department of Social Development and Welfare (2002). *Highland Communities within 20 Provinces of Thailand*. Bangkok, Department of Social Development and Welfare, Ministry of Social Development and Human Security and UNICEF.

The Border Patrol Police were sent to border areas to contain communism but they faced many difficulties, notably the inability to communicate with local people, who spoke their own dialect and did not understand Central Thai. Communism containment also took the shape of the fight against opium cultivation; by cutting the poppies it was hoped that high profits from opium trade would cease and would stop to fuel the formation of armed groups that were threatening the established government. In the heart of the Golden Triangle, hill tribes were the first target of the poppy eradication programmes, sponsored by international funders, such as the United States or the United Nations. Parallel to that, Thai and international survey teams collected data on opium production, and the highlanders' practice of opium cultivation in the highlands was made illegal in 1958 ⁴⁰.

Poppy eradication programmes put the spotlight on hill tribes and their traditional agriculture methods were pointed at, especially slash-and-burn agriculture presented as backward and jeopardizing environment through deforestation. From the perspective of the government, such ways of life were primitive and needed to be changed. Therefore, socio-economic development projects were launched in highland ethnic communities in the mid-1970s. The projects focused on opium eradication and then on poverty alleviation, improvement of health conditions, nutrition, and literacy, keeping in mind the necessity of rolling back communism.

In that respect, education in state schools was essential to hook hill tribes firmly on Thailand and deter them from being lured into communism. Teaching hill tribe people to speak, read and write Thai was essential to allow communication with government officials who were implementing development programmes. Governmental schools were a means to control hill tribes and integrate them into the modern society and economics, but also into the Thai ideological and political landscapes as the following sections will explain it further.

⁴⁰ Cultivation of opium had largely gone on even after it was made illegal by the 1958 law. Only from 1984-1985, the cultivation of opium almost stopped after the Thai government used armed forces to slash opium poppies in the field annually.

3. Extending modern education to the highlands: the role of state agencies

In 1951, the Thai state set up 'The Welfare Committee for People Far From Road Access' (*prachakon klai khamanakhom*), later renamed 'The Hill Tribe Welfare Committee' (HWC) to focus on the hill tribes ⁴¹. Many projects were designed such as the establishment of the 'Settlement for Hill Tribe Welfare' to contain hill peoples within a demarcated area in order, officially, to make it easy for government officials to conduct development and welfare activities. A socio-economic survey of Hmong, Mien, Lisu and Laha villages in highlands of three Provinces (Chiang Mai, Chiang Rai and Tak) was also conducted in 1961-1962. Recommendations from the survey report led to the establishment of the Tribal Research Center (TRC) to systematically conduct research and development among the hill tribes ⁴².

In 1963, the HWC organized sub-committees regarding education, occupation, land survey, health, radio broadcasting and the preparation for the setting up of the TRC. The HWC launched the National Integration Policy to be carried out among the hill tribes. The aim of this policy was to use education to develop and generate welfare to the hill tribes, to create qualified citizens and to increase self-reliance. Many state agencies have been involved in the establishment and administration of hill tribe schools; details of educational programmes under each agency are described below.

3.1 The Office of the Basic Education Commission

The Office (OBEC) is responsible for the management of state schools countrywide. School structure and systems are designed in a same centralized way i.e. school fee, curriculum, administrative structure etc. This has limited the access of ethnic children to school, mainly because of their low-income family

⁴¹ Hill Tribe Welfare Division (2002). *See sib pee kong song khraw chao khao* [Forty years of Hill Tribe Welfare Division]. Bangkok, Public Welfare Department, Ministry of Labour and Social Welfare.

⁴² See Manndorff, H. (1967). *The Hill Tribe Program of the Public Welfare Department*, Ministry of Interior, Thailand: Research and Socio-Economic Development. Southeast Asian Tribes, Minorities, and Nations. P. Kunstadter. New Jersey, Princeton University Press. For the rise and fall of the Tribal Research Center, see Buadaeng, K. (2006). "The Rise and Fall of the Tribal Research Institute (TRI): Hill Tribe Policy and Studies in Thailand." *Tonan Ajia Kenkyu* (Southeast Asian Studies) 44(3): pp.359-384.

background⁴³ and because their villages are far from the main road and the school.

To solve that, the OBEC has set up school branches in the highlands to teach young children from Grades 1 to 3 but villagers⁴⁴ mentioned that very few teachers really devote their time and profession to teach highland children. Teachers are usually not ethnic native people. They hardly communicate with hill tribe peoples due to language barriers and sometimes have a prejudice towards them. They find it difficult to live in remote areas with few modern technology facilities and prefer commuting to the hill school everyday.

It was reported that a lowland teacher spends only 2-3 hours a day for teaching in a hill remote school⁴⁵. He/She arrives at school at around 10am, and then takes coffee for breakfast for around half an hour before starting teaching. The break for lunch may take another two hours because students have to prepare and cook lunch for themselves at school⁴⁶. He/She may teach for another hour after lunch before returning to his/her home in the lowlands. Some days, teachers do not even come for they have to attend meetings or trainings.

To improve hill children's accessibility to state schooling, "*mobile classrooms*" have been temporarily set up in village clusters that cannot even have a school branch. This kind of temporary school needs the support from local people because they have to construct the temporary classroom, teacher's house, desks etc. while the main school or the Local Administrative Organization's office provides teaching materials and sometimes food for lunch. The initial monitoring of this project has shown good results because local communities

⁴³ Although the 1997 and 2007 constitutions stated that children must get free education for 12 years, schools still require parents to pay for many things i.e. textbooks, hiring foreign teachers, etc. Only in the first semester of the 2009 school year did the government increase its support to schools so that schools would not charge the parents for extra. However, parents still complain that they still have to pay for many things for children i.e. stationery.

⁴⁴ From the author's own research and experience of sending her children to attend a branch school in a remote hill Karen village.

⁴⁵ Data collated by Songwit Chuemskul, an official from the Ministry of Social Development and Human Security. He presented his research during the seminar on "Lessons Learned from the Development of Education for Children and Youth by Communities and NGOs in Northern Thailand", organized by the Social Research Institute, Chiang Mai University on November 28, 2008. His presentation was based on his experience when doing research for his Ph.D. thesis in a hill tribe village.

⁴⁶ Primary schools in remote areas usually get a limited amount of funding from the government to provide lunch for students.

have well cooperated, but there are some problems, such as the difficulty in communication between Thai teachers and Karen students and the insufficient number of teachers to cater to a large number of students (Damnoen 2002).

3.2 The Non-formal Education Office

In the 1940s, the Non-formal Education Office put an emphasis on teaching adults how to read and write. Later in the 1970s, the focus turned to general people who could not attend normal schools. The office established many non-formal education schools in small villages where schools following the formal system could not be set up. Volunteer teachers were hired to teach in those schools while also working with communities to develop the village.

Recently, the Office has initiated projects to help ethnic children learn better, such as the Bilingual Education which allow young children to use their own language together with Thai language. Also, the Office set up Thai classes for Burmese migrant workers' children and for camp refugees to help them better communicate with Thai people and to have access to important sources of information in Thai.

3.3 The Special Education Administrative Office

This Office is in charge of Welfare schools set up for children who cannot have access to normal schools. These children may be categorized into hill tribe, children in remote areas, orphans, children who are at risk – e.g. prone to HIV/AIDS, drug addiction, unwanted occupations, or children with disabilities. In fact, hill tribe children may fall into each category.

There are two types of welfare schools: The first is called Welfare Education Schools, the second the Royal-People Welfare School. Welfare Education Schools were set up from the 1950s to the 1970s, with one in every province inhabited by hill tribes. The first one was established in Kanchanaburi Province in 1953, and was called Phanomthuan Welfare Education School.

The Royal-People Welfare Schools were established during the last two decades. The schools are mostly situated in remote districts. Altogether, there are 45 Welfare Education Schools and Royal-People Welfare School spread across the 38 Provinces. All schools provide boarding and education free of charge.

Most of them are opened from grade 1 to grade 12. In 2005, the number of students in these 45 schools was 40,658 ⁴⁷.

3.4 The Border Patrol Police (BPP) Command Office

As stated earlier, the BPP set up schools in border areas when they found that nobody in the villages could speak Thai and schools did not exist there although a lot of children were around. They thought that if the situation remained like that, Thai national security would be threatened. Schools were set up in order to *“teach hill tribe children and people in hardship area Thai language and tradition, to be a means to create the familiarity and trust between villagers and the BPP, which is the approach to create sustainable development, leading to development in other aspects...”* ⁴⁸

The BPP has set up altogether 713 schools, but in 2005, only 191 schools remained under its control, out of which 189 were primary schools, only 2 were secondary schools. Many schools were closed because villagers had moved to other places and some schools had been transferred under the responsibility of the Ministry of Education because the areas had become easily accessible to outsiders. The 191 remaining schools are located in 40 Provinces with altogether 1,549 BPP teachers, 20 normal ⁴⁹ teachers and 30 volunteer teachers.

The BPP schools are patronized by the King and royal family members. Princess Maha Chakri Sirindhorn has initiated many projects in the BPP schools such as farming for lunch, nutrition and health promotion schemes, or scholarships for higher education.

3.5 The National Buddhism Office

In 1965, the *Sangha* set up the Dhammacharik Programme to spread Buddhism among the hill tribe people. In 1972, the Dhammacharik Programme established schools to accommodate young hill tribe boys, who were ordained as

⁴⁷ Out of the total number, 794 students are stateless people.

⁴⁸ On the history of BPP schools, see www.bpp.go.th/healthzone/clip%20art/bpp_school.htm

⁴⁹ By ‘normal teachers’ we are referring to teachers permanently employed by the Ministry of Education. They usually have an official status. Volunteer teachers are partly employed and have not been fully trained as teachers.

novices, to study from primary school to junior high school. In 1990, the programme set up another school which teaches from Junior High School (lower secondary education) to High School (upper secondary education) level. The school follows the Buddhist curriculum (*phra pariyati thamma*). Later, in 1993, with the increasing number of hill tribe novices, another school was set up to teach more novices at Junior High School level. The programme also includes a vocational school for hill tribe girls to study both core subjects and vocational subjects such as cloth making, cooking, or music.

4. Impact of modern curriculum on hill tribes

4.1 School curriculum and teaching system in highland schools

Since modern education has been used by the central government as a modern technology to gradually inculcate and convince non-Thai ethnic groups to become Thai, as stated by Cohn and Dirks (1988), central curriculum and standard Thai have only been allowed in class. Subjects and contents taught in highland schools have followed the same system as the one operated in lowland schools.

These are designed by the Centre, which is Bangkok, and then used throughout the country. That means local and ethnic knowledge has not been part of the school curriculum, with the only exception of the “*special activity*”, carried out one hour a week. In addition, only Standard Thai, as an official language, has been allowed at school.

In a highland primary school, a former Hmong student said, “*When there were patrol border police staff teaching in our school, in the late 1970s, teachers adopted soldiers’ rules in school. Hmong students were asked to strictly follow one another. If any student spoke Hmong language in school territory, friends would report to teacher; he or she will then be punished by beating on hand and running around the school field. With such way of punishment, it caused a lot of shyness and embarrassment. Soon, Hmong students were able to speak Thai fluently.*”⁵⁰

⁵⁰ Interview of Prajeen Xiong (pseudonym), a Hmong villager of Mae Sa Mai, Mae Rim District, Chiang Mai Province, 2004.

Such strict rules also existed in lowland schools throughout the country. A former Karen student stated, *"In my school classes in a lowland secondary school, my lowland Thai classmates often spoke with teachers, who were also lowlanders, in northern Thai dialect or Kham Muang. The school head teacher then set up an official rule, which was adopted from central government's policy that only standard Thai was allowed in school class. Otherwise, any student who violated the rule would be punished by beating."*⁵¹

Furthermore, school activities have been geared towards nationalism. Students learn about Thailand's three pillars: the nation, the (Buddhist) religion and the monarchy. In front of each class, above the black board, there are photos of the national flag, Lord Buddha, and His Majesty the King. The three colours of the national flag represent these three pillars. Every morning, students have to attend the national flag salute. National anthem is sung while raising the national flag up to the top of the pole. After that, students pray and chant in the Buddhist way. For the monarchy, students have to sing the song to praise the monarchy every Friday evening, before heading home. These practices are very different, if not contradictory, with hill tribes' traditions and conceptions of the world.

4.2 Impact of formal education on hill tribe people and community

Though, for about three or four decades, highland parents have eagerly wanted their children to study in modern schools, primarily for the purpose of acquiring literacy and worldwide knowledge, there are great lessons to learn about the impact of the school system.

Firstly, parents think that the more their children are enrolled in school system, the more they lose their ethnic and local knowledge. Modern education system is seen as a means to guide students and to expose them to Western knowledge and nationalism, rather than perpetuating their traditional knowledge. For example, their local and ethnic history is not a part of the *"History"* course; values and practices of local agricultural and traditional healings are not mentioned in the school curriculum; there is no room in school for local experts to transmit their wisdom to students.

⁵¹ Interview of Khamla Maneevong (pseudonym), a Karen villager of Nongtong village, Mae Wang District, Chiang Mai Province, 2008.

Secondly, the more children attend school, the less they speak their ethnic language and dress in ethnic costumes. As stated earlier, only standard Thai is allowed in class, and school teachers try to convince parents that their ethnic language is useless in the Thai context. At a village meeting of one Hmong village, a school head teacher clearly stated, *"I sometimes would like to punish your children, due to their inability to speak Thai when they first enrol at school. However, I stop my intention, since the fault is not theirs, but their parents'. Hence, I would like to strongly recommend that you, as parents, have to teach basic Thai terms to them before taking them to school. Such basic kinship terminology of father, mother, brother, sister, etc., in Thai should be taught. Otherwise, teachers would take a long time to accustom them with Thai language, before school curriculum could be started. Please avoid using your own ethnic language with children, since it is useless soon after you leave the village territory for outside."*⁵²

Up to recently, young ethnic people who had enrolled in school rarely spoke their own language. Nowadays, their children are unable to speak it: Problems of communication between grandparents and grandchildren exist in various families and ethnic groups. In addition to language, ethnic costumes have also been neglected. Young people feel reluctant to dress in traditional costumes, except for tourist attraction, because they want to hide their ethnic identity from the lowland Thai public.

Finally, modern education system, which is implemented by the state, causes inferiority and loss of self-confidence among young ethnic peoples. Because negative stereotypes regarding highlanders are conveyed, both through the school curriculum and public media, there is a real sense of shame in expressing highland ethnic identities insofar as young people feel backward and irrelevant. Examples include avoiding speaking their language or meeting their fellow ethnic members in a lowland Thai context; changing first and family names to Thai ones. Another good example case we found is that some ethnic students who attended secondary school did not want to apply within the quota for tribal students to get enrolled at Chiang Mai University, just because they did not want other friends to know about their ethnic background (Leepreecha and Trakarnthamrong 2006).

⁵² Interview of Rackchart Thaithae (pseudonym), head teacher of Mae Sa Mai School, Mae Rim District, Chiang Mai Province, 2004.

5. Attempts from Government Organizations, Non-Governmental Organizations (NGOs) and People Organizations (POs) to reform education

For the last fifty years, many state agencies have tried to provide formal education to hill tribe children by setting up schools to cover all hill areas, but in terms of accessibility, some problems have remained. Upper secondary schools are usually situated in the District town which is, for some hill villagers, still a distant place. Children cannot go back and forth, and need to stay close to the school which means more expenses to cater to living costs. If a hill tribe child wants to go to higher education, the financial burden is even heavier because most colleges and universities are located in the city. We know that among hill tribe people, some are getting rich and can afford to pay for their children's education. But the lives of most hill tribe people are still around the poverty line.

Another acute problem is the appropriateness of the curriculum and learning system. The state curriculum has been designed to create a sense of Thai-ness needed to build the nation. It has also induced the introduction of modern, "scientific" knowledge to bring hill peoples on the path towards modernization, commercialization and industrialization. For hill tribe communities, it means that ethnic and local history and culture have been neglected and traditional knowledge is progressively being forgotten. The formal education system, not based on the multicultural principle, has therefore been questioned: Should modern education be the only model to be applied in a world which becomes more and more complex?

The state educational practitioners, non-governmental development workers and community leaders have realised the limitation of formal education system and attempted to reform education, to increase its accessibility and appropriateness.

The 1997 Thai constitution provided that *"a person has equal right to receive basic education for not less than 12 years. Education must be provided by the state in large area coverage and free of charge"*. Parallel with public schools, the state established fund to grant loans and scholarships to poor students, to purchase uniforms, study equipment and material, or to cater to living expenses. But the level of the fund is still too limited compared to the needs of students.

Since 2004, educational policies have attempted to incorporate ethnic history, indigenous knowledge and culture in the school curriculum by stating, through a decree of the Minister of Education, the obligation to have 30% of the

curriculum being locally developed⁵³. But only a few schools have been able to achieve that. Examples are Jong Kham School in Mae Hong Son Province, Ban Mai Pang Kha School in Payao Province and Khob Dong School in Chiang Mai Province. Two main factors have led to their success in developing a real local curriculum: first, the appreciation and understanding of the importance of ethnic/local history, knowledge and culture. The directors of the first two schools are Shan and Mien native people, while the teacher of the last school is from Bangkok but has devoted herself to the Lahu and Palong communities, and other ethnic groups, for more than twenty years. The second factor is the active participation in the local curriculum development of ethnic communities⁵⁴.

NGOs have also played an important role in supporting hill tribe children to access formal education at upper secondary and higher education levels. Most of the NGOs, who work with hill tribe communities, get financial support from foreign donors to give students free boarding and scholarships. Having realized that formal education is not very relevant to the real life of hill tribes, NGOs have also created tailored curriculums providing alternative knowledge and the integration of indigenous knowledge and culture⁵⁵.

Regarding People's Organizations' role in education, up to now, it can be stated that local villagers have had very limited opportunities to teach their own knowledge to their children in class, despite the local content provision. In a Hmong village of Mae Sa Mai of Chiang Mai province, we found several obstacles to the implementation of the local school curriculum (Leepreecha and Wanitpradit 2009). Firstly, there are various local groups of people who attempt to teach children different subjects, such as silverware, tree plantation for reforestation, herbal medicines and mixed-crops farming, or the development of a local museum. But cooperation between them is not clear. Moreover, written

⁵³ See more details on that in Chapter 1 of this Occasional Paper.

⁵⁴ A few schools which have successfully developed the local curriculum presented their works in the seminar organized by the Research Programme "Education Systems and the Preservation of Local Wisdom and Ethnic Culture" of the Social Research Institute, Chiang Mai University, on September 7, 2007, as reported in Buadaeng, K. (2008). *Kan phathana rabob kan suksa phue anurak watthanatham lae phasa chatphan* [Developing Educational Systems for the Conservation of Culture and Language]. Chiang Mai, Research report of Social Research Institute, Chiang Mai University.

⁵⁵ See more information on the role of NGOs in supporting education for hill tribes in Buadaeng, K. (2008). *Ong korn phatana ekchon kab kan song serm kan suksa kae klum chat phan bon phuen thi sung* [Non-governmental organizations and the promotion of education among highland ethnic groups]. Chiang Mai, Research report of Social Research Institute, Chiang Mai University.

texts are scarce, teaching techniques and processes are not always appropriate, and these activities are very time-consuming for the villagers.

Secondly, teachers, especially the head teacher, feel reluctant to cooperate with villagers in integrating local wisdom in class. The priority, and the responsibility of the head teacher, is to run the school to meet the government's policy goals. The aim is to train students to compete at higher levels of education and get agriculture-based jobs. In that respect, local knowledge is less important for school teachers. In addition, school teachers' background is not an ethnic one and all of them have to travel back and forth on a daily basis between lowland home and highland village, so they pay no attention to learning to ethnic language or to create a local curriculum with villagers.

Thirdly, for some attempts, both sides, school and community, have met a common agreement but there has been no funding for the local content provision. Though there is an available source of budget from the local Sub-district (Tambon) Administration Organization (*orhotor*), a clear proposal is necessary. It needs to be developed and submitted in advance for fiscal budget allocation. In practice, no side started such process.

In a nutshell, there is still very limited space and roles for peoples' organizations in pushing their ethnic and local knowledge into the local school classroom. Therefore, it was not strange for us to find that they are presently attempting to create their own channels, outside formal schools, to succeed in passing on their knowledge to younger generations (Leepreecha and Wanitpradit 2009).

Conclusion: problems and challenges

In official discourse, the hill tribes have been portrayed negatively and with suspicions. Before the 1980s, they were viewed as a vulnerable group which was likely to side with the communists. Later, they were often stigmatized as drug producers and traders and as forest destroyers. The formal education system has been extended as a means to solve 'hill tribe' problems by inducing Thainess, and replacing traditional knowledge and culture with modern ones. As a result of intensive extension of formal education by many state agencies since the 1960s, hill tribe children and youth have increasingly been formally educated and integrated into modern Thai society. They have adopted Thai identity,

modern knowledge and culture, and gradually moved out from highland communities to find jobs and permanently settle in urban areas.

As a consequence of formal education extension, a few hill tribe people managed to gain higher education, and to find jobs leading them to a higher socio-economic status in Thai society. They have worked with governmental agencies, international and national non-governmental development organizations, religious institutions, or in the business sector. However, the overwhelming majority of hill tribe peoples have not been able to attain higher education or to reach higher levels of the society. They found work in urban areas but only got enough income for survival. They are unlikely to go back to their highland communities to work on the farm for they lack the needed knowledge and habits to stay and work as their forefathers did. If they come back, it would be more likely to hold a position in local administrative offices, nurseries, or schools, for instance.

The formal education system, which is centralized in its structure, curriculum, and regulations, is still inaccessible to ethnic marginalized people. Most people cannot afford the expenses induced by higher education, not only for school tuition but also daily expenses and others. The quality of the education delivered is also questioned for it has been largely based on Western knowledge and models, while local knowledge and culture have been neglected. The more children attend school, the less they learn about their indigenous knowledge and culture. Ethnic language and indigenous knowledge which have been developed and transmitted for hundreds of years may discontinue. The knowledge on fauna and flora which could be further studied for the production of medicine, for instance, will be lost, for the younger generation has no chance to access to this type of knowledge. This means that society as a whole will lose invaluable knowledge resources which could have been used to build alternative development in an increasingly complex and dynamic society.

However, in the last two decades, there have been attempts by the government to reform the education system to provide access for all and accommodate local knowledge and culture into the formal system, in order to provide more options for livelihoods and the development of other sectors of the society. Attempts have not yet generated clear successful results: The educational structure is still too centralized with limited participation from civil society. Revisions or improvements are slow whereas real and timely reforms are needed. NGOs and POs have worked hard to help hill tribe children to get access to higher education and develop alternative learning systems and contents. But with limited funding and manpower, they can only help a few at a time.

With many challenges ahead, the reformation of the Thai education system will not be achieved by the work of only one or two agencies. All stakeholders, the state, NGOs, POs and civil society must realize that education reform is a priority and put all their efforts together to improve the accessibility and quality of education for a better society and living.

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